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My Secret Desires

Some loves are worth the risk. Some confessions change everything.

by Walusimbi Leon (SGSS)

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A Novel

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Chapter 1 — The Distance Between Words

The coffee was cold, but Alex didn't notice.

He sat by the window of a small café in East London, watching the rain trace lazy patterns down the glass. Outside, the city moved in its familiar rhythm — double-decker buses coughing through puddles, commuters with umbrellas locked in battle with the wind, the distant rumble of the Central Line beneath his feet. It was a Tuesday afternoon in November, and the world was grey and ordinary.

His phone lay face-up on the table, the screen dark. He had been staring at it for the better part of an hour, composing and deleting the same message over and over again. The cursor blinked at him like a taunt.

Hey, I've been thinking about you. Can we talk?

No. Too vague.

Any, there's something I need to tell you. I know this might change things between us, but—

Too heavy. Too soon. Too everything.

He put the phone down and picked up the cold coffee, drinking it in one long, bitter swallow. The café was nearly empty — just an elderly man reading a newspaper in the corner and a barista scrolling through her phone behind the counter. The rain had picked up, drumming against the glass like impatient fingers.

Alex was twenty-three years old, and he had spent the last two years of his life in love with a girl who lived four thousand kilometers away.

Her name was Anya Volkova. She was twenty-two, Russian, with grey-green eyes that seemed to change color depending on the light and a laugh that made him feel like the world was briefly a better place. They had met three years ago during his second year at university — a summer exchange program in Moscow that was supposed to be about improving his Russian language skills and nothing more.

It had turned into something much more complicated.

He remembered the first time he saw her. It was on the steps of the Faculty of Journalism at Moscow State University. She was sitting with a group of friends, smoking a cigarette she clearly didn't know how to smoke properly, coughing between drags and laughing at herself. Her hair was tied in a messy bun, and she wore an oversized sweater that looked like it had belonged to her father.

She had caught him looking and raised an eyebrow.

"American?" she had asked, in English that was careful and deliberate.

"British, actually. Close, though."

"Ah. British." She had nodded as if this explained something. "Do all British men stare, or is it just you?"

He had stammered something incoherent, and she had laughed — that laugh — and motioned for him to come over. That was how it started. That was how everything started.

The exchange program lasted eight weeks. In that time, Alex and Anya became inseparable. She showed him Moscow — not the Moscow of tour guides and Red Square postcards, but the real Moscow: hidden courtyards in Kitay-Gorod, late-night walks along the Moskva River, underground concerts in basement bars where the music was too loud and the air was thick with cigarette smoke. He told her about London, about his flat in Hackney, about his dreams of becoming a writer. She told him about her family in a small town outside Nizhny Novgorod, about her complicated relationship with her father, about her ambition to become a journalist and tell stories that mattered.

They stayed up until four in the morning talking about everything and nothing. They shared a pair of earbuds on the Metro, trading songs back and forth — he introduced her to Arctic Monkeys and Radiohead; she countered with Kino and Zemfira. She taught him Russian swear words, and he taught her British slang that she insisted on using incorrectly, just to watch him cringe.

By the end of the eight weeks, Alex knew he was in love with her.

He also knew, with absolute certainty, that she did not feel the same way.

It wasn't that she was cruel or dismissive. On the contrary, she was warm, affectionate, physically demonstrative in a way that drove him crazy. She hugged him freely. She linked her arm through his when they walked. She rested her head on his shoulder during long Metro rides. She called him *drug* — "friend" — a word that in Russian carried more weight than its English equivalent, but still stopped painfully short of what he wanted.

She had a boyfriend, a law student named Dmitri who lived in Saint Petersburg and visited on weekends. Alex had met him once — a tall, serious man with a firm handshake and the air of someone who had already mapped out his entire life. Dmitri had been polite to Alex, which somehow made it worse. There was no villain in this story. Just a man who had fallen in love with someone who saw him as a friend.

The exchange program ended. Alex returned to London. He told himself it was a crush, a fleeting thing that would fade with distance and time. He was wrong. They kept in touch — messages at first, then voice calls, then video calls that stretched into the early hours of the morning. She told him about Dmitri, about her struggles with her studies, about her dreams. He listened. He always listened.

A year later, he booked a flight to Moscow. Just to see her, he told himself. Just to catch up. He stayed for ten days, sleeping on the couch in her tiny shared apartment, meeting her friends, becoming an accepted fixture in her life. Nothing happened. Everything happened. He left more in love than he had arrived.

He did it again the following year. And again, six months after that.

By the time he was twenty-three, Alex had built a life around the spaces between visits. His flat in Hackney was a testament to impermanence — sparse furnishings, a bed that folded into the wall, a bookshelf filled with Russian novels he was learning to read in the original. His job as a freelance copywriter paid the bills but demanded nothing of his heart. His days blurred into a rhythm of work, sleep, and the quiet, constant hum of unspoken words.

He had friends in London. Real friends. One of them was a girl named Jessie.

Chapter 2 — The Girl Who Wasn't Anya

Jessie was everything Anya was not.

Where Anya was tall and slender, Jessie was short and athletic, with broad shoulders and the confident posture of someone who had played rugby in university. Where Anya's English was careful and melodic, Jessie spoke in rapid-fire bursts of cockney slang that Alex sometimes struggled to follow. Where Anya was emotionally guarded, revealing herself in fragments over months, Jessie wore her heart on her sleeve and expected everyone else to do the same.

They had met through a mutual friend at a house party in Shoreditch two years ago. Jessie had challenged him to a game of

pool, beaten him soundly, and bought him a drink to apologize. They had been friends ever since.

She worked as a graphic designer for a small agency in Clerkenwell. She lived in a chaotic flat in Brixton with two roommates and a cat named Toast. She had strong opinions about things Alex had never thought about — the best kebab spot in London, the correct way to hang wallpaper, the moral implications of pineapple on pizza. She was loud and messy and brilliant, and Alex had no idea how he felt about her.

That was the problem. He had no idea how he felt about anything.

Jessie knew about Anya. Of course she did. Alex had told her early in their friendship, in the way that people confess things they haven't fully processed, hoping that saying it out loud would make it more real. Jessie had listened without judgment, nodding in the right places, asking the right questions.

"So you're in love with a girl who lives in Russia," she had said, after he finished. "And she has a boyfriend. And you've never told her how you feel."

"That's... yes. That's the situation."

"And you're telling me this because...?"

"Because I don't know what to do."

Jessie had taken a long sip of her beer, studying him with an expression he couldn't read. "Well," she had said finally, "you're going to have to tell her eventually, mate. Otherwise you're just going to sit in your flat forever, reading Russian books and crying to Arctic Monkeys."

"I don't cry to Arctic Monkeys."

"Sure you don't."

That was Jessie. She cut through his carefully constructed walls with blunt honesty and a complete lack of sentimentality. She made him laugh. She made him forget, for a few hours at a time, that there was a girl four thousand kilometers away who held his heart in her hands without knowing it.

And sometimes — on good nights, when they stayed up too late watching terrible movies and drinking cheap wine — Alex wondered if maybe Jessie was the answer. If maybe the solution to his Anya problem was right here in London, in a messy flat in Brixton, in the form of a girl with strong opinions about pineapple on pizza.

But it never went further than wondering. Every time he thought about crossing that line, he stopped. Because Jessie deserved someone who was fully present, not someone who was using her as a distraction from a girl he couldn't have.

And so he kept both relationships suspended in a state of careful balance — Anya in Russia, Jessie in London, and Alex somewhere in the middle, too afraid to move in either direction.

Chapter 3 — The Confession

The message was sent on a Thursday night, at 11:47 PM London time.

Alex had been pacing his flat for an hour, rehearsing words that sounded wrong no matter how he arranged them. He had drunk half a bottle of wine to steady his nerves, which was probably a bad idea, but he had stopped caring about good ideas somewhere around the fourth glass.

Anya, can I call you? It's important.

He sent it before he could change his mind.

The response came three minutes later, though it felt like three hours.

Of course, drug. Is everything okay?

He called her. The line connected, and he heard her voice — slightly confused, slightly worried, familiar in a way that made his chest ache.

"Alex? What's wrong?"

"Nothing's wrong. I mean, nothing's wrong in a bad way. It's just... there's something I need to tell you. And I've been trying to tell you for a long time, but I've been too scared."

There was a pause on the other end. He could hear her breathing, the faint sound of a television in the background.

"You're scaring me a little," she said, her voice softer now.

"I'm sorry. I don't mean to. It's just... Anya, I'm in love with you."

The words hung in the air between them, across four thousand kilometers of fiber optic cable, across three years of friendship and carefully suppressed feelings. He said them again, because once didn't feel like enough.

"I'm in love with you. I have been since Moscow. Since the night we walked along the river and you told me about your grandmother's dacha. Since you taught me that Russian word — *toska* — that longing for something you can't quite name. I've been carrying this for three years, and I can't carry it anymore."

Silence. He could hear his own heartbeat.

"Alex..." Her voice was barely a whisper. "I don't know what to say."

"You don't have to say anything. I'm not asking you for anything. I just... I needed you to know. I needed to stop pretending."

She was crying. He could hear it in her voice, the way it cracked on the edges of words. "Why didn't you tell me before?"

"Because I was afraid of losing you. Because I thought if I said it out loud, it would change everything. And maybe it will. But I

couldn't keep living in this half-life, loving you from a distance, never knowing if there was even a chance."

"Alex..." She said his name like it cost her something. "I don't know what to say to you. I need time. I need to think."

"Take all the time you need."

"I want to see you," she said suddenly. "Can you come to Moscow?"

His heart stopped. "What?"

"Come to Moscow. I want to see you. I want to talk about this properly, not over the phone."

"When?"

"Next week. I'll send you the dates."

He said yes. Of course he said yes. He would have said yes to anything she asked.

They talked for another hour — about mundane things, about the weather in Moscow and her work and the book she was reading. The confession hung between them like an unopened gift, acknowledged but not yet unwrapped. When they finally said goodnight, Alex lay in bed staring at the ceiling, his heart pounding so hard he thought it might break through his ribs.

He was going to Moscow. He was going to see her. And for the first time in three years, he had no idea what would happen when

he got there.



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